

Domain or Tenant Policy Modification

Sub-techniques (2)



Adversaries may modify the configuration settings of a domain or identity tenant to evade defenses and/or escalate privileges in centrally managed environments. Such services provide a centralized means of managing identity resources such as devices and accounts, and often include configuration settings that may apply between domains or tenants such as trust relationships, identity syncing, or identity federation.

Modifications to domain or tenant settings may include altering domain Group Policy Objects (GPOs) in Microsoft Active Directory (AD) or changing trust settings for domains, including federation trusts relationships between domains or tenants.

With sufficient permissions, adversaries can modify domain or tenant policy settings. Since configuration settings for these services apply to a large number of identity resources, there are a great number of potential attacks malicious outcomes that can stem from this abuse. Examples of such abuse include:

- modifying GPOs to push a malicious [Scheduled Task](#) to computers throughout the domain environment^{[1][2][3]}
- modifying domain trusts to include an adversary-controlled domain, allowing adversaries to forge access tokens that will subsequently be accepted by victim domain resources^[4]
- changing configuration settings within the AD environment to implement a [Rogue Domain Controller](#).
- adding new, adversary-controlled federated identity providers to identity tenants, allowing adversaries to authenticate as any user managed by the victim tenant ^[5]

Adversaries may temporarily modify domain or tenant policy, carry out a malicious action(s), and then revert the change to remove suspicious indicators.

Mitigations

ID	Mitigation	Description
M1047	Audit	Identify and correct GPO permissions abuse opportunities (ex: GPO modification privileges) using auditing tools such as BloodHound (version 1.5.1 and later) ^[6] .
M1026	Privileged Account Management	Use least privilege and protect administrative access to the Domain Controller and Active Directory Federation Services (AD FS) server. Do not create service accounts with administrative privileges.
M1018	User Account Management	Consider implementing WMI and security filtering to further tailor which users and computers a GPO will apply to. ^{[2][7][8]}

Detection Strategy

ID	Name	Analytic ID	Analytic Description
DET0270	Detection of Domain or Tenant Policy Modifications via AD and Identity Provider	AN0755	Adversary modifies Group Policy Objects (GPOs), domain trust, or directory service objects via GUI, CLI, or programmatic APIs. Behavior includes creation/modification of GPOs, delegation permissions, trust objects, or rogue domain controller registration.

ID: T1484

Sub-techniques: [T1484.001](#), [T1484.002](#)

① Tactics: [Defense Impairment](#), [Privilege Escalation](#)

① Platforms: Identity Provider, Windows

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[Version Permalink](#)

References

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2. [Robbins, A. \(2018, April 2\). A Red Teamer's Guide to GPOs and OUs. Retrieved March 5, 2019.](#)
3. [Schroeder, W. \(2016, March 17\). Abusing GPO Permissions. Retrieved September 23, 2024.](#)
4. [MSRC. \(2020, December 13\). Customer Guidance on Recent Nation-State Cyber Attacks. Retrieved December 30, 2020.](#)
5. [Okta Defensive Cyber Operations. \(2023, August 31\). Cross-Tenant Impersonation: Prevention and Detection. Retrieved February 15, 2024.](#)
6. [Robbins, A., Vazarkar, R., and Schroeder, W. \(2016, April 17\). Bloodhound: Six Degrees of Domain Admin. Retrieved March 5, 2019.](#)
7. [Microsoft. \(2008, September 11\). Fun with WMI Filters in Group Policy. Retrieved March 13, 2019.](#)
8. [Microsoft. \(2018, May 30\). Filtering the Scope of a GPO. Retrieved March 13, 2019.](#)